The Hiding Place

By Corrie ten Boom

CORRIE: **(Pg 82-83)** The true horror of Nazi occupation came over us only slowly. During the first year of German rule there were only minor attacks on Jews in Holland. A rock through the window of a Jewish-owned store. An ugly word scrawled on the wall of a synagogue.

[But over time], Father and I saw the symptoms spread. A sign in a shop window: JEWS WILL NOT BE SERVED. At the entrance to a public park: NO JEWS. On the door of the library. In front of restaurants, theaters, even the concert hall.

Worst were the disappearances. We never knew whether our Jewish friends had been spirited away by the Gestapo or gone into hiding. Public arrests, with no attempt to conceal what was happening, were becoming more frequent. One day as Father and I were returning from our walk, we found a truck parked in front of the fish mart; into the back were climbing men, women and

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children, all wearing the yellow star. ***"Father! Those poor people!"***

FATHER: Those poor people. I pity the poor ***Germans***, Corrie. They have touched the Jews: the apple of God's eye.

CORRIE: We talked often, Father, [my sister] Betsie and I, about what we could do if a chance should come to help some of our Jewish friends.

INTRODUCTION

They didn't have to wait long. . . In this true story, 50-year-old Corrie Ten Boom and her 80-year-old father open their home to Jews who are hiding from Hitler's Gestapo. The Ten Booms were not Jews themselves, but Christians – Christians committed to caring for the needs of others, no matter what the cost.

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WOMAN: **(Pg 91)** *(Knock on door)* Can I come in? *(voice is high-pitched in fear)*

CORRIE: Of course. *(steps back)*

WOMAN: *(Looks over her shoulder)* My name is Kleermaker. I'm a Jew.

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CORRIE: **(Pg 92)** Just two nights later the same scene was repeated. Again there was a furtive knock at the side door. This time an elderly couple was standing outside. It was the same story: the same tight-clutched possessions, the same fearful glance. The story of neighbors arrested, the fear that tomorrow their turn would come. **(Pg 96)** Still the hunted people kept coming, and the needs were often more complicated. If a Jewish woman became pregnant, where could she go to have her baby? If a Jew in hiding dies, how could he be buried?

(Pg 97) We were friends with half of Haarlem! We knew nurses and clerks in the Records office. We knew someone in every business and service in the city.

CORRIE: **(Pg 112-113)** Good morning, Pastor. Would you be willing to take a Jewish mother and her baby into your home? They will almost certainly be arrested otherwise.

PASTOR: *(Takes a step back. Color drains from his face)* Miss Ten Boom! I do hope you're not involved with any of this illegal concealment and undercover business. It's just not safe! Think of your father! And your sister!

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CORRIE: On impulse I told the pastor to wait and ran upstairs. I asked the mother's permission to borrow the infant. Back in the dining room, I pulled the coverlet from the baby's face.

PASTOR: *(Long silence. He bends forward, his hand reaching for the tiny fist. Compassion and fear struggle on his face. Then he straightens)* No. Definitely not. We could lose our lives for that Jewish child!

CORRIE: Unseen by either of us, Father had appeared in the doorway.

FATHER: Give the child to me, Corrie. *(Holds the baby close, brushing his beard against the child's check. Looks at the pastor)* You say we could lose our lives for this child. I would consider that the greatest honor that could come to my family.

CORRIE: **(Pg 99-102)** [In time] one of the most famous architects in Europe; I knew him only as Mr. Smit, paid us a visit.

MR. SMIT: Your building lacks a secret room. This is a danger for all, those you are helping as well as yourselves.

CORRIE: He started up the narrow corkscrew stairs. At last, at the very top of the stairs, he entered my room.

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MR. SMIT: You want your hiding place as high as possible. Gives you the best chance to reach it while the search is on below. This is it!

CORRIE: Over the next few days the false wall was up; 30 inches from the back wall. Even I who had lived half a century in this room could scarcely believe was not the original. And in the far lefthand corner, a sliding panel, two feet high and two wide, opened into the secret room.

MR. SMIT: The Gestapo could search for a year. They'll never find this one! **(Pg 118)** A raid may come any day. Your secret room is no good to you if people can't get to it in time. Put a buzzer in every room with a door or a window on the street. Then hold practice drills until your people can disappear in that room without a trace in less than a minute.

CORRIE: [We] installed a buzzer near the top of the stairs – loud enough to be heard all over the house but not outside. Buttons were placed to sound the buzzer at every vantage point where trouble might first be spotted. A Mr. Smit arrived one morning to teach me how to conduct the drills.

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MR. SMIT: (Pg 119) Mealtimes. hat's the favorite hour for a raid. Also the middle of the night. *(Walks from room to room, pointing to evidence)* Watch for evidence that more than three people live in the house. Wastebaskets and ashtrays. If the raid comes at night, they must not only take their sheets and blankets, but get the mattress turned. That's the S.D.'s *(Security Police's)* favorite trick – feeling for a warm spot on a bed.

CORRIE: *(Buzzer)* Mr. Smit pushed the button. People sprang to their feet, snatching up glasses and plates, scrambling for the stairs.

JEWS: Faster! Not so loud! You're spilling it!

CORRIE: (Pg 120) The whole process had taken four minutes. A little later we were all gathered again around the dining room table. Mr. Smit set before him the incriminating evidence he had found: two spoons and a piece of carrot on the stairs, pipe ashes in an "unoccupied" bedroom.

The next night I sounded the alarm again and this time we shaved a minute thirty-three seconds off our run. By our fifth trial, we were down to two minutes.

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(Pg 139) It was the morning of February 28, 1944. For two days I had been in bed with influenza. **(Pg 141)** In my fevered dream a buzzer kept ringing. On and on it went. Why wouldn't it stop? Feet were running, voices whispering: "Hurry! Hurry!"

I sat bolt upright. People were running past my bed. I turned just in time to see [someone's] heels disappear through the secret panel.

But . . . I hadn't planned a drill for today! Who in the world – unless – unless it wasn't a drill. **(Pg 142)** I dropped the panel down and pushed by prison bag up against it. I had just reached the bed when the door flew open.

SOLDIER: What's your name?

CORRIE: What? *(Corrie sits up slowly and sleepily)*

SOLDIER: Your name!

CORRIE: Cornelia Ten Boom

SOLDIER: *(Turns and shouts down the stairs)* We've got one more up here. *(Turns back to Corrie)* Get up! Get dressed! *(Takes a slip of paper from his pocket and consults it. Looks at Corrie with new interest)* So you're

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the ring leader. Tell me now, where are you hiding the Jews?

CORRIE: I don't know what you're talking about.

SOLDIER: **(Pg 144)** *(striking her across the face)* Where is your secret room?

CORRIE: Lord Jesus, protect me!

SOLDIER: *(raises his hand to strike again, but then stopes)* If you say that name again I'll kill you.

CORRIE: **(Pg 143)** It was the hardest thing I had ever done to turn and walk out of that room. The man behind me gave me a push and I hurried down the stairs to the dining room. Father and Betsie were sitting on chairs against the wall. **(Pg 147)** I would not let myself think about the secret room and the six people [the hiding place] upstairs.

(Pg 149-150) In the Smedestraat a wall of people pressed against police barricades set across the street. As Betsie and I stepped out with Father between us, a murmur of horror greeted the sight of "Haarlem's Grand Old Man" being led to prison. In front of the door stood a green city

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bus with soldiers occupying the rear seats. Father, Betsie, and I squeezed into a double seat near the front.

(Pg 153) The truck had no springs and bounced roughly over the bomb-pitted streets. I slipped my arm behind Father's back to keep him from striking the edge. The truck jerked to a halt. Behind us massive gates clanged shut.

SOLDIER: (Pg 154) Women prisoners follow me!

CORRIE: Father! God be with you!

FATHER: And with you, my daughters.

CORRIE: I turned and followed the others. Behind me the door slammed closed. ***Oh Father, when will I see you next?***

(Pg 161) We were heading deep into the maze of prison passageways. Without a word, the prison matron halted in front of a door and opened it with a key. I stepped inside. The door clanged behind me. The bolt slammed shut. ***Alone. Alone behind these walls . . . I must not let my thoughts run wildly; I must be very mature and very practical. Six steps. Sit down on the cot.*** It reeked; the straw seemed to be fermenting. I reached for the

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blanket: someone had been sick on it. I thrust it away, but it was too late. *(Turn back to audience. Dry heaves)*

What had I done to be separated from people this way? Maybe my sentence was solitary confinement for years and years . . .

(Pg 162) The door opened once a day to let in a man from Medical Supply with some stinging yellow liquid from a very dirty bottle. ***Please!*** *(raspy voice; clutching at his sleeve)* ***Have you seen an 84-year old man – white hair, a long beard? Casper Ten Boom! You must have taken medicine to him!***

MEDICAL MAN: *(Tugging loose)* I don't know! I don't know anything!

CORRIE: The cell door slammed back against the wall.

PRISON MATRON: Solitary prisoners are not permitted to talk!

CORRIE: (Pg 164) It seemed to me strangely important not to lose track of time. I scratched a calendar on the wall behind the cot. As each long featureless day crawled to a close, I checked off another square. I also started a record of special dates beneath the calendar:

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February 28, 1944	***Arrest***
February 29, 1944	***Transport to Scheveningen***
March 16, 1944	***Beginning of Solitary***

(Pg 166) One evening as I was crossing another long, long day from the calendar scratched on my wall, I heard shouts far down the corridor. They were answered closer by. Now noisy voices came from every direction. Names were being passed from cell to cell. People were singing, others pounding on their doors. The guards must all be away!

CORRIE: What's happening? Where are the guards? *(Crying out through the open slot)*

PRISONER: At a party. It's Hitler's birthday.

CORRIE: Then – these must be their own names people were shouting down the corridor. This was our chance to tell where we were, to get information. ***I'm Corrie Ten Boom! My whole family is here somewhere! Oh, has anyone seen Casper Ten Boom! Betsie Ten Boom!*** I shouted names until I was hoarse and heard them repeated from mouth to mouth down the long corridor. After a while, answers began to filter back. Some of the messages I could hardly bear to relay: "To my husband

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Joost: our baby died last week . . ." Along with personal messages were rumors about the world outside: "The Allies have invaded Europe!" *(beat)* **(Pg 167)** At last some of the names I had shouted began to return.

PRISONERS: Betsie Ten Boom is in cell 312. She says to tell you that God is good!

CORRIE: As far as I could discover, every single one taken in the raid – with the exception of Betsie and me – had been freed. Only about Father could I discover no news at all although I called his name over and over into the murmuring hall. No one seemed to have seen him. No one seemed to know . . .

(Pg 169) It was the third of May. I was sitting on my cot when the food shelf in the door banged open and shut with a single motion. And there on the floor of the cell lay a letter -- Nollie's writing. Why should my hand tremble as I picked it up? The letter had been opened by the censors – held by them too: the postmark was over a week old. But it was a letter from home – the very first one! Why this sudden fear? *(Unfolds the paper)* "Corrie, can you be very brave?" . . .

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CORRIE: ***No! No, I couldn't be brave!*** *(reading)* I have news that is very hard. Father survived his arrest by only ten days. He is now with the Lord . . ." No details, not how or where he died, not even where he was buried. *(reacts to a sound in the corridor)* Footsteps were passing . . . "Please! I've had bad news – oh please, don't go away"

(Pg 170) A jangle of keys - the cell door opened. "This letter just came. It says that my father – it says that my father has died."

GUARD: Your father . . . *(then coldly)* Whatever happens, you brought it on yourself by breaking the laws!

CORRIE: *(long beat, then she begins to pray)* **"**Dear Jesus! How foolish of me to have called for human help when you are here. To think that father sees you now, face to face! To think that he and Mama are together again, walking those bright streets . . . "

I pulled the cot from the wall and below the calendar scratched another date:

March 9, 1944 ***Father. Released.***

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Corrie ten Boom
ISBN: 978-0800794057
Publisher: Chosen Books
Date (Month/Year): Jan 2006

AWARD HISTORY

IL State Qualifier

Find out more about Corrie Ten Boom and her family.

https://encyclopedia.ushmm.org/content/en/article/corrie-ten-boom

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